A wave of chatter swept across the crowd that had already started to disperse. But I quietly sat there, still trying to let it sink in. Nobody congratulated me, except for Hema. ‘So you get to fly,’ she said, trying hard to hide her own disappointment at not being recommended. ‘Congratulations, Gunjan.’

I hugged her. I was elated at my selection, yet sad that Hema had to go.

‘Here’s my telephone number,’ Hema said, handing me a piece of paper. ‘Call me when you come for medicals at IAM [Institute of Aerospace Medicine] in Bangalore. We’ll catch up. Now hurry up and go to Manoj Sir’s office.’

We hugged each other, and she left. Sqn Ldr Yadav informed me that my medical tests were scheduled to be held at IAM Bangalore, the same place where Hema’s mother worked in the administration wing. I was directed to an office where I was asked to fill up certain forms. My ticket to Bangalore was handed to me before I was freed for lunch. I ran straight to the STD booth and informed my parents of the result.

‘Everything I ever believed has been proven right,’ said an elated Papaji.